Widows and Children First!

By Harvey Fierstein

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Meet Arnold, the gay son of a Jewish mother who is an expert at avoiding the truth.*
ACTOR: *Arnold and his partner Allen had plans to adopt a son from the foster care system . . . a teen-age boy named David who social services felt would benefit from have two well-adjusted gay parents, to help him deal with his own homosexuality.*
ACTRESS: *Unfortunately for everyone, Allen did not live to see the adoption through.*
ACTOR: *And now Arnold's mother, still grieving the death of her own husband has arrived for a visit.*
ACTRESS: *The stage is set for . . .*
TOGETHER: *Widows and Children First! By Harvey Fierstein*

ARNOLD: *[Coming out of kitchen and speaking to David (off-stage)]* Did your teacher happen to mention how Oscar Wilde came to be imprisoned? He was in jail for being gay.

MA: *[Embarrassed]* Arnold, I can't find the oil.

ARNOLD: In a minute, Ma. See, ten years earlier, the Parliament passed a law against homosexuality. And Oscar Wilde had this young lover named . .

MA: Arnold, could you please give me a hand?

ARNOLD: Just a second. His name was Lord Alfred. Now, Lord Alfred's father found out about them and started causing scenes in public; chasin' 'em outta hotels and stuff.

MA: For God's sake, Arnold. Could you change the subject?

ARNOLD: *[Annoyed]* I'll finish later. *[Goes back to kitchen]* I wish you wouldn't interfere like that; it's very embarrassing.

MA: Excuse me, but listening to that is very embarrassing.

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ARNOLD: I'm sorry you feel that way, but I have a responsibility to his education.

MA: I am sure that the people who put him here did not have that kind of education in mind.

ARNOLD: The people who put him here had exactly that kind of education in mind. And I'll thank you not to interfere.

MA: I am only suggesting that you should consider the huge responsibility you've taken on here.

ARNOLD: You think I'm unaware of it?

MA: Then act like it. You should be setting an example for the boy.

ARNOLD: And I'm not?

MA: Not when you talk like that, you're not. You've got to consider what you say to him for the remaining time. He's at an impressionable age. After all it's only for a few more months.

ARNOLD: What's for a few more months?

MA: He's here on a nine-month program, right? And he's already been here six months, so . . .

ARNOLD: And what do you think happens then?

MA: He leaves.

ARNOLD: David is here on a nine-month program, but after that, if we agree and the Bureau of Child Welfare allows, I will legally adopt David. And believe me, Ma, if I have anything to say about it, he's not leaving. *[Ma tries to say something, she is angry, confused, frustrated. She throws down whatever is in her hands and sits on couch. Arnold follows and stands staring at her. Sits next to her. Pause]* Is this it? We gonna sit and stare into space?

MA: You want I should do a Bubble Dance? Frankly, Arnold, you've done a

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lot of crazy things, but this . . . ?

ARNOLD: Adopting David is not a crazy thing. It's a wonderful thing that I'm very proud of.

MA: If you're so proud how come you were too ashamed to tell your mother? Everything else you tell me. You shove your sex-life down my throat like aspirin; every hour on the hour. But six months he's been here and not a word. Why?

ARNOLD: Ma . . . Y'know, you're not the easiest person in the world to talk to.

MA: What did I say? Do I tell you how to run your life? You want to know why you didn't tell me about this? I'll tell you why: Because you knew it was wrong.

ARNOLD: That's not true.

MA: No?

ARNOLD: No! This isn't something I decided to do overnight. We put in our application more than two years ago.

MA: Who "we"?

ARNOLD: Alan and I.

MA: The two of you were going to do this together? Now I've heard everything.

ARNOLD: That's what I love about you; you're so open minded.

MA: Alright. So, Alan's not here. Why's the kid?

ARNOLD: Because with everything else I forgot about the application. Then, one day, the phone rang. It was the foster parent program and they had David for us. I told them what happened to Alan and they said I could probably take David anyway.

MA: And you said, "send him on over."

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ARNOLD: Not at first. But then I thought it all through, called them back and said yes . . . On a trial basis.

MA: I'm glad you got a money-back guarantee, but you still haven't told me why you wanted him.

ARNOLD: Because I was tired of widowing. Widow-ing . . . feeling sorry for myself, cursing every time I passed a couple walking hand in hand, watching Tear Jerkers on T.V. knowing they could only cheer me up. Christ, of all the things going down here, I was sure that was the one thing I wouldn't have to explain.

MA: How should I know about Wida-whating? Did you ever say a word to me?

ARNOLD: I didn't think I had to. Christ, it's only been three years since daddy died.

MA: Wait, wait, wait, wait, wait. Are you trying to compare my marriage with you and Alan? *[Haughty and incensed]* Your father and I were married for thirty-five years, had two children and a wonderful life together. What loss did you have? You fooled around with some boy. You have the nerve to compare that to a marriage of thirty-five years?

ARNOLD: You think it doesn't? Ma, I lost someone that I loved very much . . .

MA: So you felt bad. Maybe you cried a little. But what would you know about what I went through? Thirty-five years I lived with that man. He got sick, I brought him to the hospital and you know what they gave me back? A paper bag with his watch, wallet and wedding ring. How could you possibly know what that felt like. It took me two months until I could sleep in our bed alone, a year to learn to say "I"

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instead of "we." And you're going to tell me you were "widowing." How dare you!

ARNOLD: You're right, Ma. How dare I. I couldn't possibly know how it feels to pack someone's clothes in plastic bags and watch the garbage pickers carry them away. Or what it feels like to forget and set his place at the table. How about the food that rots in the refrigerator because you forgot how to shop for one? How dare I? Right, Ma? How dare I?

MA: *[Starting over his speech and continuing until her exit]* May God strike me dead! Whatever I did to my mother to deserve a child speaking to me this way. The disrespect! I only pray that one day you have a son and that he'll talk to you like this. The way you talk to me.

ARNOLD: *[Over her speech]* Listen, Ma, you had it easy. You have thirty-five years to remember, I have five. You had it easy, Ma. You lost your husband in a nice clean hospital, I lost mine out there. They killed him there on the street. Twenty-three years old laying dead on the street. Killed by a bunch of kids with baseball bats. *[Ma has fled the room. Arnold continues to rant.]* Children. Children taught by people like you. 'Cause everybody knows that queers don't matter! Queers don't love! And those that do deserve what they get! *[He stops, catches his breath, sits down] [Long pause while Arnold composes himself]* . . . . Ma, I'm sorry I lost my temper. Please come out here. We can't talk like this.

MA: *[In doorway]* You don't want to talk, you want to fight.

ARNOLD: You wanna sit down?

MA: *[Wandering over to the couch]* I'm sitting. *[Warning]* And don't holler at me. People say things they don't mean when they holler and you've already said quite enough.

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ARNOLD: I won't holler. You just hit a raw nerve. We won't discuss Alan. Only David.

MA: So discuss.

ARNOLD: Why don't you tell me what you already know, and we'll go on from there.

MA: Let me think. He's an orphan . . .

ARNOLD: He's not an orphan. He was a battered child. They took him away from his parents. This is his third foster home. The first brought him back. The second he ran away from. So . . .

MA: Arnold, darling, open your eyes. Don't you see how ridiculous this is? I've been here less than a day, already I've seen you let him miss school, hang out on the street, go out without dinner . . .

ARNOLD: This isn't Little Lord Fauntleroy we're talking about here. If this kid decided I was coming down too hard on him, he'd pack and take off and I'd never get him back again.

MA: So you let him run wild?

ARNOLD: No. But I don't beat him up either. I teach him. I advise him, I try to set an example for him . . .

MA: Some example. Arnold, look, you live the life you want. I don't say a word. This is what you want. But think about the boy. He told me he loves you. He sees you living like this . . . don't you think it's going to affect him?

ARNOLD: Ma, David is gay: the whole purpose of placing him here was for him to grow up with a positive attitude about his homosexuality.

MA: That's it. *[Stands]* I'm finished.

ARNOLD: You think this is easy for me? Look; my hands are shaking. I've been

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like this for days knowing you'd be coming and we'd have to talk about this.

MA: Because you knew I'd show you how wrong you are.

ARNOLD: I'm not wrong.

MA: No? Tell me something: How old was your friend Alan when you met him?

ARNOLD: Seventeen.

MA: Seventeen. Seventeen and you were doing God knows what together. Now tell me; how old is this "son" of yours?

ARNOLD: I have no intention of sleeping with him if that's what you're driving at.

MA: I had no intention of having a homosexual for a son. So, look where intentions get you. Arnold, do what you want. You want to live like this? I don't care anymore. You're not going to make me sick like you did your father.

ARNOLD: I made my father sick?

MA: No; he was thrilled to have a fairy for a son! You took a lifetime of dreams and threw them back in his face.

ARNOLD: What lifetime of dreams? He knew I was gay for fourteen years.

MA: What? You think you walk into a room, say, "Hi Dad, I'm queer," and that's that? You think that's what we brought you into the world for? Believe me, if I'd known I wouldn't have bothered. Arnold, you're my son, you're a good person, a sensitive person with a heart, like your father, and I try to love you for that and forget this. But you won't let me. You've got to throw me on the ground and rub my face in it. You haven't spoken a sentence since I got here without the

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word "Gay" in it.

ARNOLD: Because that's what I am. You want a part in my life? I am not going to edit out the things you don't like! There is nothing I need from anyone except love and respect. And anyone who can't give me those two things has no place in my life. *[Breath]* You are my mother, and I love you. I do. But if you can't respect me . . . Then you've got no business being here.

MA: You want me to leave? I'm leaving. You want me to fight? I'm too tired. You want me to change? I'm too old and I can't. I can't, I can't, I can't. So you do what you have to do, and I'll do what I have to do and I hope you're satisfied. *[Arnold groans]* You can't put all the blame on me. It's not fair. Your "friend" Alan . . . How was I supposed to know?

ARNOLD: Why? You would have understood?

MA: Maybe. Maybe not. You can't know for sure. But I flew up for the funeral and you never said a word.

ARNOLD: So you could've done what? Tell me he's better off dead?

MA: Or maybe I could've comforted you. Told you what to expect. You and your "widowing." *[She turns to leave, stops, takes a breath. One last try.]* You've got an unusual way of looking at things, Arnold Beckoff.

ARNOLD: Runs in the family. Ma, I miss him so much.

MA: Give yourself time, Arnold. It gets better. But, Arnold, it won't ever go away. You can work longer hours, adopt a son, fight with me . . . whatever, it'll still be there. It becomes part of you, like wearing a ring or a pair of glasses. You get used to it and it's good . . . because it makes sure you don't forget. You don't want to forget him, do you?

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[Arnold shakes his head] So, it's good. *[Pause]* I guess that's what I would have said . . . if I'd known.

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AWARD HISTORY

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